

Allegiance to Gratitude

Worksheet answers | Robin Wall Kimmerer

Based on all 11 photos uploaded October 5: reading pp. 83-99 and both worksheet pages. The opinion portions of Questions 2, 4, and 5 and the personal response in Question 6 are sample responses; adjust them to match your views.

1) This essay begins with a short anecdote about the author's daughter who refuses to say the Pledge of Allegiance at school. Then, the author tells the story of the children at the Onondaga Nation School saying the Thanksgiving Address. Make a bullet-point list of the things the children are thankful for.

- Each other as people and the continuation of life.
- Mother Earth, who gives them what they need to live.
- Water, which quenches thirst and supports all life.
- Fish, which help clean the water and provide food.
- Plant life, which supports many other living things.
- Berries, especially strawberries, which provide food.
- Food plants, especially the Three Sisters, which feed people and other living things.
- Medicine herbs and the people who know how to use them for healing.
- Trees, especially the maple, for shelter, shade, fruit, sugar, and other gifts.
- Animals, which share their lives with people and teach them.
- Birds, especially the eagle, for their songs and watchfulness.
- The Four Winds, which refresh the air and bring changing seasons.
- The Thunder Beings, which bring rain that renews life.
- The Sun, which brings light and supports life.
- The Moon, which lights the night, governs tides, and helps measure time.
- The stars, which brighten the night and help guide travelers.
- Enlightened Teachers, who teach people to live in harmony.
- The Creator, or Great Spirit, for the gifts of Creation and the love in the world.

Source: illustrated Address, pp. 86-87; full Address throughout pp. 88-99.

Purposes and meaning

2) As you read the essay, make a list of all the purposes the Thanksgiving Address serves for the children/community. Do you agree with the author's statement that it's "good medicine for land and people alike" (93)?

- Makes gratitude a daily habit and encourages contentment instead of always wanting more (pp. 91-93).
- Brings people together through shared attention, agreement, and common ground (pp. 91-92, 95).
- Preserves the community's language and expresses its cultural identity and sovereignty (pp. 85, 88).
- Teaches how the natural world works and how its parts support life (pp. 89-91).
- Shows that good leadership means generosity, wisdom, service, and sacrifice (pp. 93-94).
- Teaches respect for other species and reminds humans that they depend on the rest of nature (p. 94).
- Supports diplomacy and decisions based on consensus (p. 95).
- Helps people notice environmental damage and encourages them to repair it (p. 96).
- Explains responsibilities, reciprocity, and how people should live together; connects the community to other beings as relatives (pp. 97-99).

I agree that it is good medicine for both land and people. Appreciating what we already have can make us less focused on buying more things and more aware of the people and natural resources that support us. That gratitude also gives us a reason to reduce waste and protect the environment. It benefits the land when people turn their appreciation into action.

3) As you read the essay, pay attention to what lines are repeated. What is the effect of these repeated lines? What is the listener's role (91)?

The line "Now our minds are one" is repeated throughout the Address, along with phrases that offer greetings and thanks. The repetition gives the Address a steady rhythm and brings everyone back to a shared feeling of gratitude. Listeners must concentrate, consider what is being said, and respond together. Their attention returns the speaker's gift, so they actively help create unity instead of just letting the words pass by (pp. 91-92).

4) The author suggests that children would be unlikely to rebel against reciting the Thanksgiving Address. Why does she think so? Do you agree or disagree? Explain.

Kimmerer thinks children would be unlikely to rebel because the Address thanks the earth for real gifts, such as berries, that they can recognize and enjoy. Her daughter objects to the Pledge because its promises of liberty and justice do not match what she sees, and being forced to say it contradicts liberty (p. 84). In contrast, Kimmerer says, "It seems hard to argue with gratitude for berries" (p. 90). I mostly agree because thanking nature is easier to connect to everyday life. Still, some children might resist if participation were forced or the words did not match their beliefs.

Personal responses

5) What do you think of the Thanksgiving Address? Could our modern society benefit from reciting something like this? Explain.

I think the Thanksgiving Address is a meaningful reminder that our lives depend on other people and the natural world. Modern society could benefit from a similar practice because people often focus on what they lack instead of what already supports them. Taking time to name those gifts could encourage cooperation, less waste, and more care for the environment. The Address's emphasis on finding common ground could also help people work through disagreements (pp. 93-95). A practice like this would matter most if people understood it and followed their words with action.

6) If you were to write your own thanksgiving address, name four things you would express thanks for.

- The people who care for me and support me.
- Teachers and the opportunity to learn.
- Clean water and the plants that provide food.
- Trees and other living things that keep the environment healthy.